

Protecting Older Adults from Online Scams

Goup Student ID: qnbg66, pndc13, mrkk13, wmjw86, pmkg46, pbjz56, hqtb85

Introduce

We noticed that

Many apps for older adults are easier to use, but they may also expose users to scams and misleading ads.

An interesting pattern is

Better accessibility can also increase trust, making older users more likely to believe deceptive content.

This suggests an opportunity to

Design digital platforms that are both accessible and protective.

It would be valuable if we could

Create systems that detect suspicious content and warn older users before they engage with it.

Our ideal Customers:

Older adults living alone

They may have no children, close friends, or family members to ask for advice, making them more likely to face scams alone and make risky decisions without support

Low-income older adults

They may be more easily attracted by offers that promise discounts, rewards, or financial benefits, which makes them more vulnerable to misleading advertisements and fraud.

Less-educated older adults

They may have lower digital literacy and weaker ability to identify false or misleading information, making it harder for them to recognize scams online.

Key evidence

In 2023, consumers aged 60 and above in the United States reported more than \$3.4 billion in fraud losses. This shows that older adults remain highly vulnerable to online scams, especially when digital accessibility is not matched with adequate protection.

Potential Segment 1: Older adults living alone

- What are they afraid of : Being cheated without realizing it
- Losing money and having no one to help
- Making the wrong decision alone

Potential Segment 2: Low-income older adults

- What are they afraid of?
- Losing limited savings
- Missing an important discount or benefit
- Financial insecurity

Potential Segment 3: Less-educated older adults

- What are they afraid of?
- Making mistakes online
- Clicking the wrong link
- Being embarrassed for not understanding technology

- What do they love?
- Simple explanations
- Easy-to-use systems
- Clear warnings
- Confidence when using technology

solution

We propose a digital safety system for older adults that can detect suspicious advertisements, warn users before they interact with harmful content, and provide simple guidance to help them make safer online decisions.

Challenges

False alarms / inaccurate detection

The system might mistake normal advertisements for scams or overlook truly dangerous content.

How to overcome it:

Combine automated detection with human review and continuously improve the model using user reports

Source

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3), 2023 Elder Fraud Report, 2024

Group users

Lei Chu, Wenzhuo Zhang, Junxi Bao, Tianyu Jiang, Xiangjin Huang, Tianhao Li, Junliang Liu.